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The tournament accurately reflected the ever-increasing high-risk nature of modern-day T20 cricket. A record 780 sixes were hit during this edition of the T20 World Cup, an increase of more than 50 per cent from the previous highest (517 sixes in 2024). The number of fours stood at a whopping 1,434, a drastic uptick from 961 in the last tournament. The aggregate boundary percentage was also at an all-time high of 18.28, eclipsing the previous best of 15.42 registered in the inaugural edition in 2007. The title-winning Indian team led the boundary-hitting charts, with 106 maximums — 30 more than the next best, West Indies — and 147 fours, 30 in excess of fellow finalist New Zealand.

Spinners operating in the PowerPlay, a phase where quicker bowlers are generally preferred, was a huge tactical success in this T20 World Cup. They bowled a combined 186.2 overs during the field restrictions — the most ever in a single edition — picking up 56 wickets at an economy rate of 8.23. Finger spinners such as Aryan Dutt, Mujeeb Ur Rahman, Will Jacks, Rachin Ravindra, and Akeal Hosein were particularly effective in keeping attacking opening combinations on a leash while also prising them out. This strategy even prompted

India to alter its left-hander-heavy top three by slotting in the right-handed Sanju Samson.

Despite the increasing emphasis on power-hitting, the 2026 T20 World Cup also placed a high value on running between the wickets. The tournament logged 5,383 singles, twos and threes — the most registered in a single edition. At spin-friendly venues with large boundaries, such as those in Sri Lanka, middle-overs strike rotation was key, and even the most aggressive batting units, such as India and England, were attuned to this reality. They ran the hardest, picking up 461 and 436 ones, twos and threes respectively.

Strategic match-ups and spin-friendly conditions meant that part-time spinners were a big hit, making an impact beyond their primary roles. Rachin had bowled only five overs in New Zealand's group-stage campaign. Yet he emerged as a potent wicket-taking option in the Super Eights, picking up seven scalps in Colombo and three more in the semifinal and final.

Pakistan captain Salman Ali Agha's part-time off-spin was employed only once, but his surprise introduction threw a curveball at the Indians when the marauding Abhishek Sharma fell in the first over of the high-stakes contest. South Africa skipper Aiden Markram also threw a spanner in the works by sending Ishan Kishan packing for a duck.

South Africa, at the peak of its powers, found it hard to shake off the 'chokers' tag yet again. It was the only team that trumped the eventual champion, India, and barring a nervy double Super Over win against Afghanistan, looked in complete control until it ran into the Kiwis in the semifinal.

South Africa seemed poised to clinch a maiden World Cup title until Murphy's Law made an inauspicious visit at the Eden Gardens. 'Anything that could go wrong went wrong' as all the Protean hopes unravelled in a matter of hours. The top three batters were back in the hut inside the first eight overs, and a 170-run chase was reduced to dust by Finn Allen's marauding 33-ball 100, leaving in its wake a band of distraught Saffers and a bitterly familiar aftertaste.

Maximum glory: A record 780 sixes were hit during this edition of the T20 World Cup, an increase of more than 50 per cent from the previous highest (517 sixes in 2024). PTI